Low-Fidelity Prototypes: Design Rationale

Purpose

Our paper prototypes apply four people-centred design concepts from class to one goal: helping visitors find APSS research and move easily between the research site, the main APSS website and reportneedles.ca. Each team member sketched one page of the APSS research website by hand.

Prototypes

#	Page	Designer	Main idea
P1	Home	Chop Peter Kur	Short menu, Browse Projects button, project cards, latest publications and blog
P2	Project page	Samuel Willis	Details box beside an image, cycling info cards, updates list
P3	Project Details	Muhammad Mouzzan	Back link, overview, details box, impact stats, updates, Get Involved
P4	Publications	Oluwateniola Fayokun	Breadcrumb, publication search, article and poster cards, featured research
P5	Research Blog	Marie Basler	Keyword search and a list of dated blog cards

Photos of all five sketches are in our team GitHub repository under design/prototypes.

Design concepts

Concept	What it means	Where it appears in our prototypes
Affordances and signifiers	An element's look suggests how to use it, and signifiers show where to act.	**P1:** "Browse Projects →" is a boxed button, and ↗ marks links that leave for the main APSS site or reportneedles.ca. **P3:** "Read more" and "Get Involved" are drawn as buttons. **P5:** a magnifying glass marks the search bar, and "…" shows an excerpt continues.
Gestalt: similarity, proximity, common region	People see items that look alike, sit close together or share a box as one group.	**P1:** the three project cards share one layout (image, title, status). **P3:** three equal stat boxes read as one set of impact figures. **P4:** articles and posters sit in separate sections of matching, labelled cards. **P5:** every blog card repeats image, date, heading and excerpt.
Constraints	Limiting the possible actions keeps paths clear and prevents errors.	**P1:** the main menu has only three sections. **P2:** project details are limited to five fixed fields (status, location, research, partners, date), and the cycle list shows one info card at a time. **P4:** each section shows two items, with "View all →" for the rest, and the search covers publications only.
Feedback and consistency (digital wayfinding)	The interface shows where you are and works the same way on every page.	**P4:** "Research" is underlined in the menu, and a breadcrumb (Home / Research / Publications) shows the visitor's location. **P3:** "← Back to projects" gives a clear way back. **All:** every page shares the same footer (contact, privacy/terms, acknowledgements).

Reference

Norman, D. A. (2013). *The design of everyday things* (Revised and expanded ed.). Basic Books.